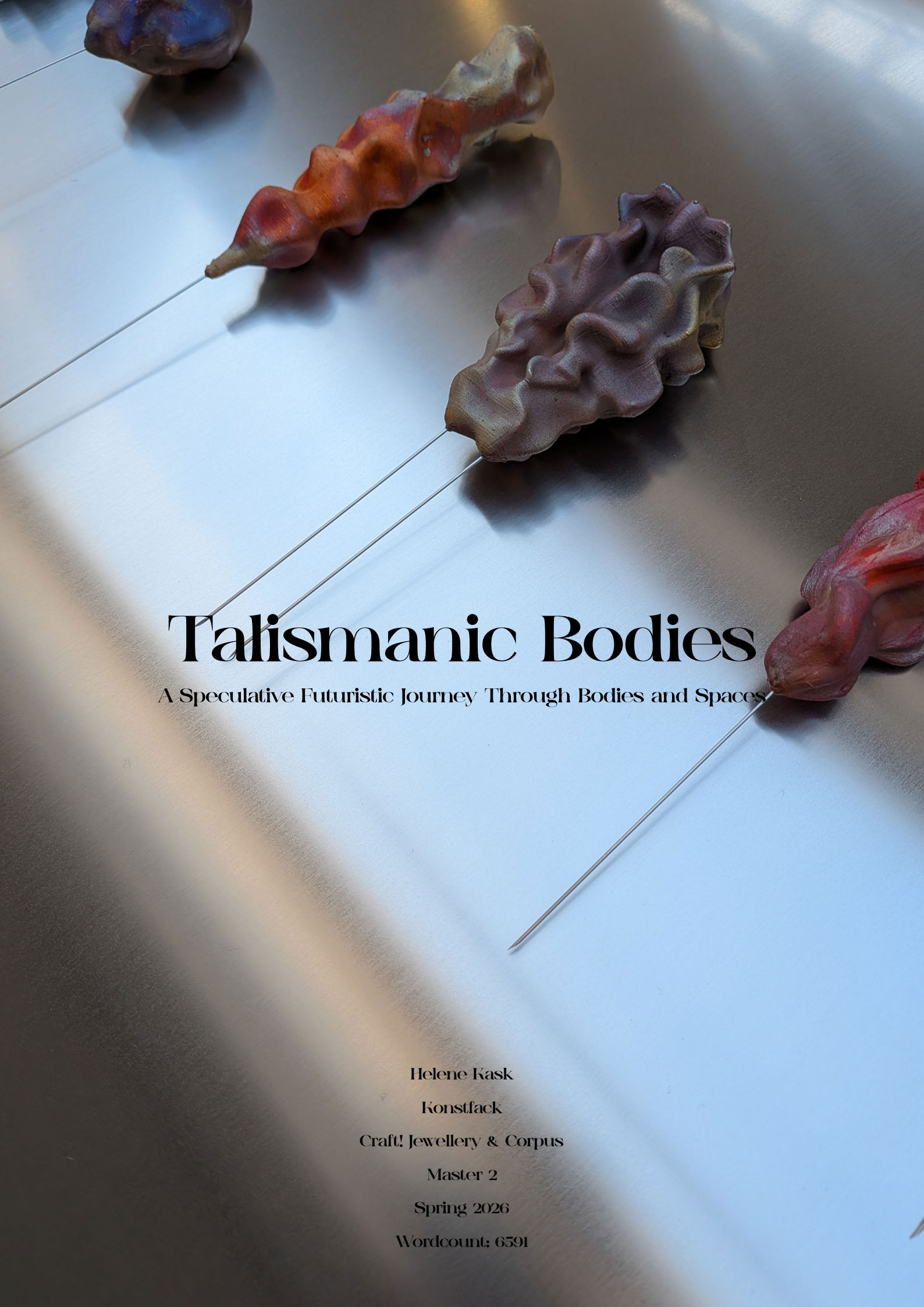


Talismanic Bodies

A Speculative Futuristic Journey Through Bodies and Spaces

Helene Kask

Konstfack

Craft! Jewellery & Corpus

Master 2

Spring 2026

Wordcount: 6591

Abstract

In my master's project, Talismanic Bodies, I have explored futuristic scenarios and the types of protective qualities our bodies might need for future survival. Through a critical lens I have examined our contemporary era and the dystopian trajectory of the Anthropocene, while suggesting more symbiotic ways of approaching life.

This investigation has been conducted through the medium of jewelry, exploring how it can function as a speculative, conceptual, and critical method. The project has been grounded in two core theoretical and conceptual frameworks, Speculative Craft and the Hybrid Laboratory, drawing inspiration from speculative thinking as well as posthuman and more-than-human philosophies.

From this foundation, three conceptual ideas have been introduced to explore different bodily protective qualities. Through the concepts of the Craftist and Cyborg Crafting, the project has unfolded how science and technology have influenced this work. The final result has taken the form of an installation that poses what-if questions; rather than providing answers, it has aimed to open up discussions about more promising futures. Functioning as a catalyst for the expansion of thought, encouraging the dream of the impossible becoming possible.

Keywords: Speculative Craft, Hybrid Laboratory, Symbiosis, Bodily Modifications, Talismans, Jewelry, Craftist, More-than-human, Posthuman.

Contents

Glossary 1

Introduction 2

Speculative Craft 3

The Hybrid Laboratory 7

Conceptual idea no. 1 - Shedding 11

Conceptual idea no. 2 - Organisms 16

Conceptual idea no. 3 - Liquid gold 23

Conclusion 27

Bibliography 30

List of images 32

Appendix contextual references 35

Appendix reflection 42

Glossary

The following vocabulary is presented in alphabetical order. Please note that footnotes are not included in this list, they are instead found throughout the paper. Terms marked with an asterisk (*) are original concepts developed specifically for this project.

Term:	Definition:
Anthropocene	A proposed geological epoch defined by the significant and often negative impact of human activity on Earth's ecosystems.
Becoming-with	A term coined by Donna Haraway, suggesting that identities and entities emerge through their entangled relationships with their surroundings.
Bodily Modifications	Derived from Haraway's use of bodily, this term also references traditional body Modification, a practice of permanently altering the body for aesthetic or ritualistic purposes.
Craftist *	A craft practitioner whose work and methodology are significantly influenced by scientific inquiry.
Hybrid Laboratory *	A conceptual framework where all artistic research for this project occurs.
Making-with	A concept from Donna Haraway suggesting that creation is inherently relational, arising from cooperation.
More-than-human	A perspective that challenges human-centric lenses, instead emphasizing that the flourishing of all species is deeply interconnected.
Posthuman	A philosophical and critical theory that decenters the human and instead proposes symbiotic relationships between humans, technology, and the environment.
Speculative Craft *	A craft-based methodology used in this project that utilizes imagination and dreaming to explore potential futures.
Symbiotic	Refers to living together, in this context, it emphasizes relational thinking and shared agency.
Talismanic	Relating to Talismans - objects believed to possess protective qualities for the wearer.
Vibrant Matter	A concept by Jane Bennett suggesting that non-human materialities possess their own inherent agency and vitality.

Introduction

Welcome to a speculative, futuristic journey through bodies and spaces. Talismanic bodies investigates how jewelry can function as a speculative method to examine possible futuristic scenarios and explore bodily protective qualities we may require to survive.

This project embarks in the Anthropocene; addressing a damaged planet, and my own anxieties regarding the future. Through craft, I navigate speculative journeys, employing artistic, scientific, and critical methods to expand my thinking and making. We travel through planetary evolution, posthuman and more-than-human philosophies, using the medium of craft and jewelry as a way of challenging how things are, and instead thinking of how things could be. It is a multifaceted adventure through science, technology, and biology, where craft and jewelry materialize different speculative destinations along the way. Furthermore, a personal experience has made a profound impact on this project: becoming a mother. Bringing new life into this world has increased my fear of a dystopian future, yet it has also served as a major catalyst for re-imagining what we need for survival. It has sharpened my artistic focus and deepened the project's intent. This work is born from hybrid ways of thinking and making, an urgent request to expand our perceptions of what it means to be human and to begin living in harmony with our surroundings. It is a call for a symbiotic existence and a step toward a more promising future.

So, take my hand. I will guide you through this journey; we are in this together.

In terms of the paper's layout, I integrate a variety of images to complement the text, emphasizing aspects of my arguments and visualizing my process to create a layer of visual storytelling. I have also experimented with different fonts to signify various layers of the narrative. This specific font is used when a speculative character is speaking. *Another font indicates references to books, texts, and articles, and is also applied to specific terminology mentioned for the first time, such as the specialized vocabulary of posthumanism.*

In the first chapter, I dive into Speculative Craft, discussing how it is used as a method. I expand on how posthuman and more-than-human thinking serve as sources of inspiration and modes of critical reflection. I expand on why Lynn Margulis's *serial endosymbiosis theory* serves as a conceptual foundation in this project.[1] Drawing from the book *Speculative Everything,* I discuss how a specific speculative design methodology can be applied to this work.[2] Furthermore, I expand on why the writings of Donna Haraway, particularly *Staying with the Trouble*, are vital to this framework.[3]

In the second chapter, I introduce the Hybrid Laboratory: a space for dreaming, imagination, and exploration. I explain why I define myself as a Craftist while discussing how my craft-based artistic method is similar to scientific inquiry. Additionally, I expand on the use of storytelling and fictional characters—alter egos—while continuing my engagement with Haraway's work.

Following this, I expand on three different conceptual ideas in separate chapters: Shedding, Organisms, and Liquid Gold. In each, I unfold the origin of the concept, my making process, and the reflections gathered along the way. I discuss how each theme relates to jewelry and the concept of protection, diving into specific theoretical references before concluding with how they will be materialized within the exhibition context.

The paper ends with a summary of the project, reference lists of bibliography and images and appendix with both contextual references and a reflection of the examination and spring exhibition.

[1] Lynn Margulis, *The Symbiotic Planet: A New Look at Evolution,* London: Orion Publishing Group, 1998.
[2] Anthony Dunne and Fiona Raby, *Speculative Everything: Design, Fiction, and Social Dreaming,* Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2013.
[3] Donna Haraway, *Staying with the Trouble: Making Kin in the Chthulucene,* Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2016.

Speculative Craft

Imagining possible futures

Image 1: NASA, *Bubble Nebula*, 1990.



Image 2: NASA, *Space Colony Art: Stanford Torus Interior,* 1975.



Image 3: Helene Kask, *Talismanic Bodies,* 2022.

We are living in troubled times... (The voice of the Cobra, who will be introduced later in the paper)

> ”Anthropocene” is the proposed name for a geologic epoch in which humans have become the major force determining the continuing livability of the Earth. The word tells a big story: living arrangements that took millions of years to put into place are being undone in the blink of an eye. The hubris of conquerors and corporations makes it uncertain what we can bequeath to our next generations, humans and not humans.[4]

In *Arts of Living on a Damaged Planet*, Anna Tsing and others capture the deep fear I have for the future, a fear that has increased drastically since the birth of my child. I wonder: what is the future of our planet? Will my son have enough food and water, or will resources be depleted? Will he survive dangerous mutated viruses and bacteria? Will he be freezing cold or overheated due to extreme changes in temperature? Or will our planet remain a mere burned-out, empty crust, as materialized by the heated metallic pieces in Image 3?

These are the dystopian scenarios I explore in this project. While dealing with these heavy, existential questions, I find inspiration and comfort in two closely related frameworks that respond to and critique the Anthropocene: posthumanism and more-than-human philosophies. Emerging from the 1980s onward, these philosophies share a common ground that serves as the foundation for my work. In short, they urge us to step away from a human-centric world view and shift our perspective toward more relational ways of living.

[4] Anna Tsing, Heather Swanson, Elaine Gan, and Nils Bubandt (eds), *Arts of Living on a Damaged Planet: Ghosts and Monsters of the Anthropocene,* Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2017, p. 1.

Troubled by our planet's future, I find grounding—and comfort—in the interconnected patterns that have sustained existence across vast stretches of time. Biologist Lynn Margulis's *serial endosymbiosis theory* serves as a conceptual foundation and in *The Symbiotic Planet,* she describes life not as a collection of individuals but as symbiotic assemblages and collaborative networks.[5] My work integrates this philosophy by exploring speculative symbiotic processes and the bodily modifications they generate as tools for survival. By materializing these hypothetical ideas, I aim to expand the viewer's perception of what is and, more importantly, what could be.

In *Speculative Everything,* Anthony Dunne and Fiona Raby explore speculation within the context of design, discussing how speculation invites perspectives of what could be instead of what is. This is achieved through indications, gestures, suggestions, imagination, and exploration. Dunne and Raby examine how design can be used for critical discussions, by posing questions formulated as *what-if* scenarios. By asking questions instead of providing answers, this approach opens up space for alternative thoughts that both expand and challenge our perceptions.[6]

Ever since I was a little girl, I have used creativity to imagine alternative worlds and fantasy creatures, weaving speculative stories of faraway places and other versions of beings where the impossible becomes possible. This found expression through the power and magic of making and writing. Literature has been fundamental to me from an early age, books work like portals or passages to other worlds, unlocking journeys and transporting us through both time and space. By using imagination, storytelling, and speculation as methods in my work, I stay true to the sources of inspiration discovered in my youth. In practice, my speculative process begins by formulating a research-based concept into a what-if question inspired by Dunne and Raby. This question guides both my thinking and making, serving as an open-ended invitation that offers endless possibilities for exploration. Because I choose not to provide answers, I consider these questions as guidelines for curiosity and expansion. I intentionally use the word use could instead of can, asking, what if we could...?

I use the medium of craft and jewelry to hope and dream, but also to question the world we live in and the direction in which we are heading. By materializing these thoughts, I aim to expand the viewer's perception of how things are, or perhaps, how things could be. While my conceptual ideas may never be physically possible, I believe that by suggesting the impossible, we expand our own horizons. Speculation allows me to address my fears, ask questions, and imagine alternatives. I speculate about different protective qualities or survival mechanisms our bodies could possess, a process that gives me hope and comfort. In Talismanic Bodies, I dream about what could be possible in the future. Ultimately, I suppose dreaming is my own survival mechanism.

> Dreams are powerful. They can inspire us to imagine that things could be radically different than they are today, and then believe we can progress toward that imaginary world.[7]

[5] Margulis, *The Symbiotic Planet,* p. 6, 101-105.
[6] Dunne & Raby, *Speculative Everything,* p. 2, 34-35, 44, 57, 70.
[7] Stephen Duncombe, *Dream: Re-imagining Progressive Politics in an Age of Fantasy,* New York: The New Press, 2007, page 182, cited in Dunne & Raby, *Speculative Everything,* p. 1.



Image 4: Shoshana Dubiner , *Endosymbiosis,* 2012.

In *Staying with the Trouble,* Donna Haraway employs *speculative fabulation* to present the *Chthulucene,* a critique of the human-centric Anthropocene. She envisions a world of *symbiogenesis*, a concept rooted in Lynn Margulis's endosymbiosis theory. Haraway describes this as *becoming-with* and *making-with,* emphasising that nothing is self-created but is instead relational and interconnected.[8] This making-with is vital to my work. A steel pipe responds to heat, altering its appearance through my hands and body as I bend it, a dancing conversation between materiality and maker. Craft is never self-created; it becomes through cooperation. I create with the materials, responding to the metal's actions as it responds to mine; a relational act of mutual becoming.

> It matters what thoughts think thoughts. It matters what knowledges know knowledges. It matters what relations relate relations. It matters what worlds world worlds. It matters what stories tell stories.[9]

Furthermore, Haraway refers to a painting, made by Shoshana Dubiner in 2012, created as an homage to Lynn Margulis, which reflects the theory of endosymbiosis. Haraway describes the painting as: "Critters interpenetrate one another, loop around and through one another, eat each other, get indigestion, and partially digest and partially assimilate one another, and thereby establish sympoietic arrangements that are otherwise known as cells, organisms, and ecological assemblages".[10] There is a striking connection between Haraway's description of symbiosis as an assemblage and the landscape of art. In both fields, the concept signifies a practice of bringing separate fragments into a new, shared context. Perhaps our future planet is exactly that: an assemblage of different hybridizations consisting of living and non-living entities. This is what I explore and speculate upon in my Hybrid Laboratory, a concept I will expand on in the next chapter.

[8] Haraway, *Staying with the Trouble,* p. 35, 53.
[9] Haraway, *Staying with the Trouble,* p. 35.
[10] Haraway, *Staying with the Trouble,* p. 58.



Image 5: Helene Kask, *Talismanic Bodies,* 2022.

Imagine.

You are standing in front of a door with a sign: The Hybrid Laboratory. You push the door open and enter. Your first encounter is a large studio space. You see a wall covered with research; mind maps, images, material tests and post-it notes with scribbles on them. In the center of the room, various objects and experiments are spread across the floor. You also notice doors leading out from this space. One door is labelled Chemicals, another 3D printing. A third door leads to the Metal Workshop, and a fourth to Sculpting.

Welcome to the Hybrid Laboratory.

Let us start by putting on our white lab coats, as the laboratory has been filled with shimmery metal dust this past year. It is still in the air, can you smell it?

This is a place where investigation, experimentation, and crafting occur. It is a space for dreams and imagination, for possible futures and bodily modifications. The beauty of the laboratory is its fluidity. It transforms itself, becoming whatever I wish for or need. Everything in this laboratory is in a state of ongoingness.

Each day, I put on my lab coat and become a Craftist, exploring different conceptual ideas through my hands and body. The reason it is called hybrid is that everything in here blends. Biology, science, technology, philosophy and craft merge into new symbiotic assemblages, a fusion between reality and imagination.

(The voice of The Hybrid Laboratory)



Image 6: Helene Kask, *Talismanic Bodies,* 2025.

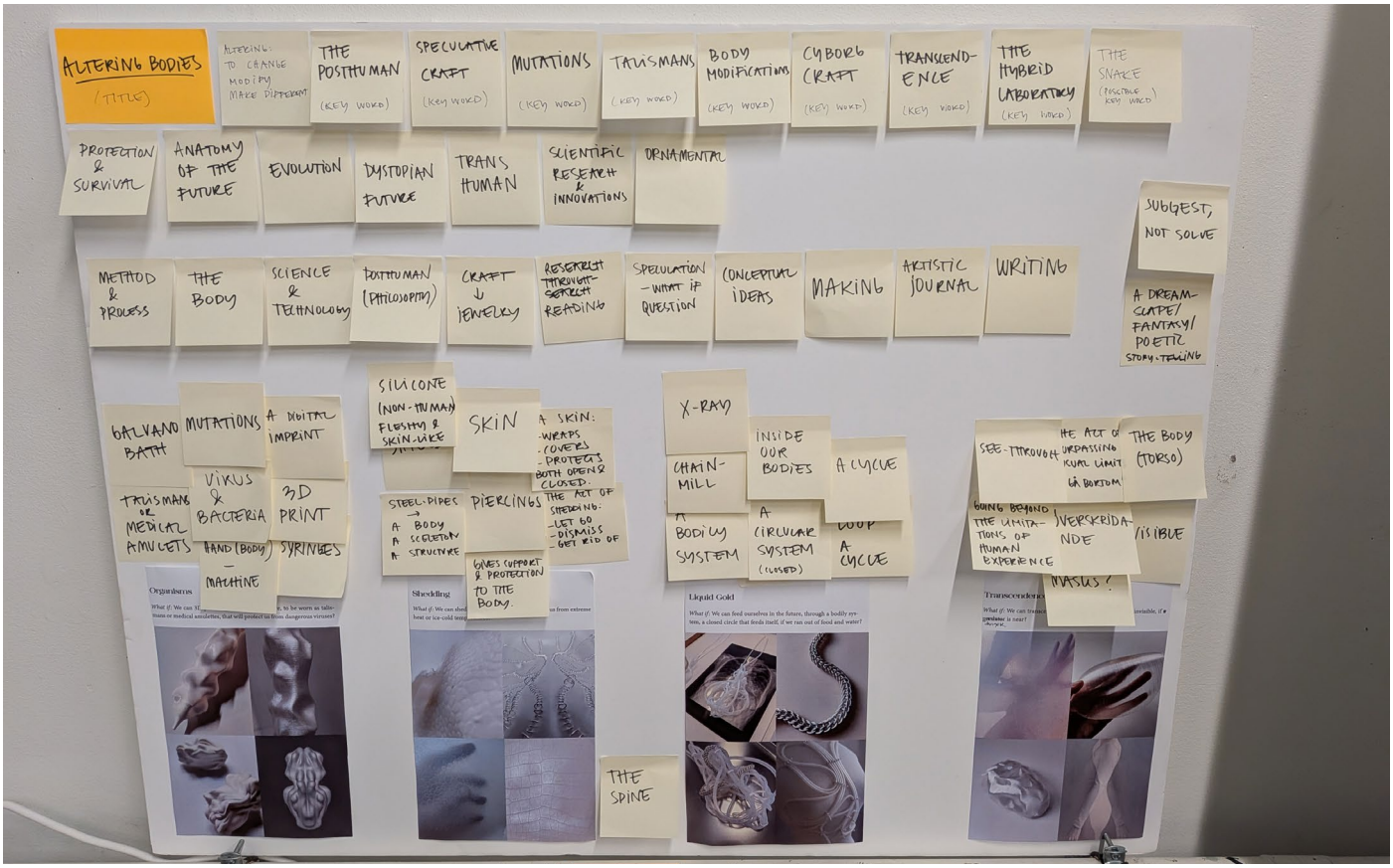


Image 7: Helene Kask, *Talismanic Bodies,* 2025.

The laboratory possesses a voice of its own; at times, I even speculate about becoming the laboratory myself. It moves across disciplines, which is why it is defined as hybrid. I view myself as a Craftist—a practitioner influenced by science—and I draw significant inspiration from scientific discoveries, integrating them as conceptual foundations for my work. By adopting a practice-based approach, the laboratory is not merely a physical space, but the process of making itself.

Science, much like craft, relies on creative thinking. By integrating concepts from both science and jewellery, my process becomes a symbiogenesis, a making-with. My artistic method closely mirrors the scientific framework: I make observations through initial research, reading, and writing, and formulate a what-if question to guide my investigations. I develop a hypothesis, which in my practice takes the form of a conceptual idea. From there, I conduct experiments by exploring materiality through the act of making, and finally, I analyse the results through reflection and writing. I draw conclusions within the artistic diaries I keep or, as in this instance, within this paper.

What distinguishes my method from a scientific one is that my questions and hypotheses cannot be measured or proven right or wrong, which are standard requirements in science. My expectations for the outcome differ entirely from those of traditional science; my analysis and conclusions do not aim to provide definitive answers, but rather to open discussions and invite further questioning.

Storytelling is an important aspect of my artistic process, and I use multiple voices within this project as creative tools. These voices function as fictional characters, or alter egos, tools that mirror what Donna Haraway calls *speculative fabulation.* In *Staying with the Trouble,* Haraway introduces Camille, a child of the Compost, whose narrative unfolds across five generations from 2025 to 2425. Haraway uses Camille to present ideas of posthuman survival.[11] In a similar way, I use fictional characters to navigate the fluid, speculative landscape of my project. Just as Camille allows Haraway to think beyond the limits of human frameworks, my alter egos push me to expand my thinking and embrace a more-than-human perspective.

Two characters have guided me into this exploration, besides the voice of the hybrid laboratory. The first is Leona, a scientist whom I channel during creative writing to help visualize the possibilities of an imaginary laboratory. The second is the Cobra, a snake that began surfacing in my work completely unintentionally. Initially, this reptilian presence surprised me, as my original intent was to focus exclusively on the human body. However, much like Haraway's critique of human-centrism, I began to realize that limiting my work to only humans was problematic. Since I have come to embrace symbiotic relationships in my practice it is entirely fitting that these characters have integrated themselves into my making. The hybridizations of the human, the animal, and the microscopic are precisely what define the laboratory as hybrid.

Furthermore, Haraway speculates about *bodily modifications* among Camille's people, which is interesting since it connects to the context of jewelry.[12] These modifications occur on a cellular level, challenging how we think about traditional body modifications, even though some body modifications today can be seen as both controversial and challenging in a contemporary jewelry context. Haraway speculates that:

> A few genes and a few microorganisms from the animal symbiont are added to the sym-child's bodily heritage at birth, so that sensitivity and response to the world as experienced by the animal critter can be more vivid and precise for the human member of the team. The animals themselves are not modified with human material; their role in the symbiosis is to teach and to flourish in every way possible in dangerous and damaged times.[13]

I was amazed to read this, as my work explores this very concept. In one of my conceptual ideas I speculate on bodily modifications influenced by animals and explore the act of shedding skin, and this will be expanded upon in the next chapter.

[11] Haraway, *Staying with the Trouble,* p. 143.
[12] Haraway, *Staying with the Trouble,* p. 140.
[13] Haraway, *Staying with the Trouble,* p. 140-147.

Conceptual idea no. 1

Shedding

Image 8: Helene Kask, *Talismanic Bodies,* 2022.

What if our bodies could shed skin in the future to protect us from extreme heat or ice-cold temperatures?

(The voice of the Cobra)



Image 9: Helene Kask, *Talismanic Bodies,* 2022.



Image 10: Helene Kask, *Talismanic Bodies,* 2022.

Skin has always fascinated me; I am amazed by its diverse qualities and capacities. How it wraps, covers, and protects us in different ways. I think of skin almost like a shield or armour.

(The voice of the Cobra)

I read a scientific article about growing artificial skin in laboratories, which led me to begin experimenting with latex and silicone, creating artificial skins in my own Hybrid Laboratory. I imagined how I could produce skins that function as protective shields. As I developed different textures, they all took on an animalistic quality, and the presence of the snake became clearly visible in my experiments as shown in the process images above.

What if we could harness the snake's unique qualities for protective purposes in the future? What can a snake teach us? I began focusing on the snake's ability to shed its skin. Shedding plays a vital role in maintaining a snake's health; it allows for growth, removes old or damaged tissue, and eliminates parasites.[14]

Could I use shedding as a survival mechanism?

[4] Matilda Sjöholm, *Ormarnas (Serpentes) makroskopiska anatomi,* Master's thesis, University of Helsinki, 2018, p. 12, https://helda.helsinki.fi/items/22998970-c485-4bbe-ba4d-a4757fdfb36e/full/, 1 March 2026.

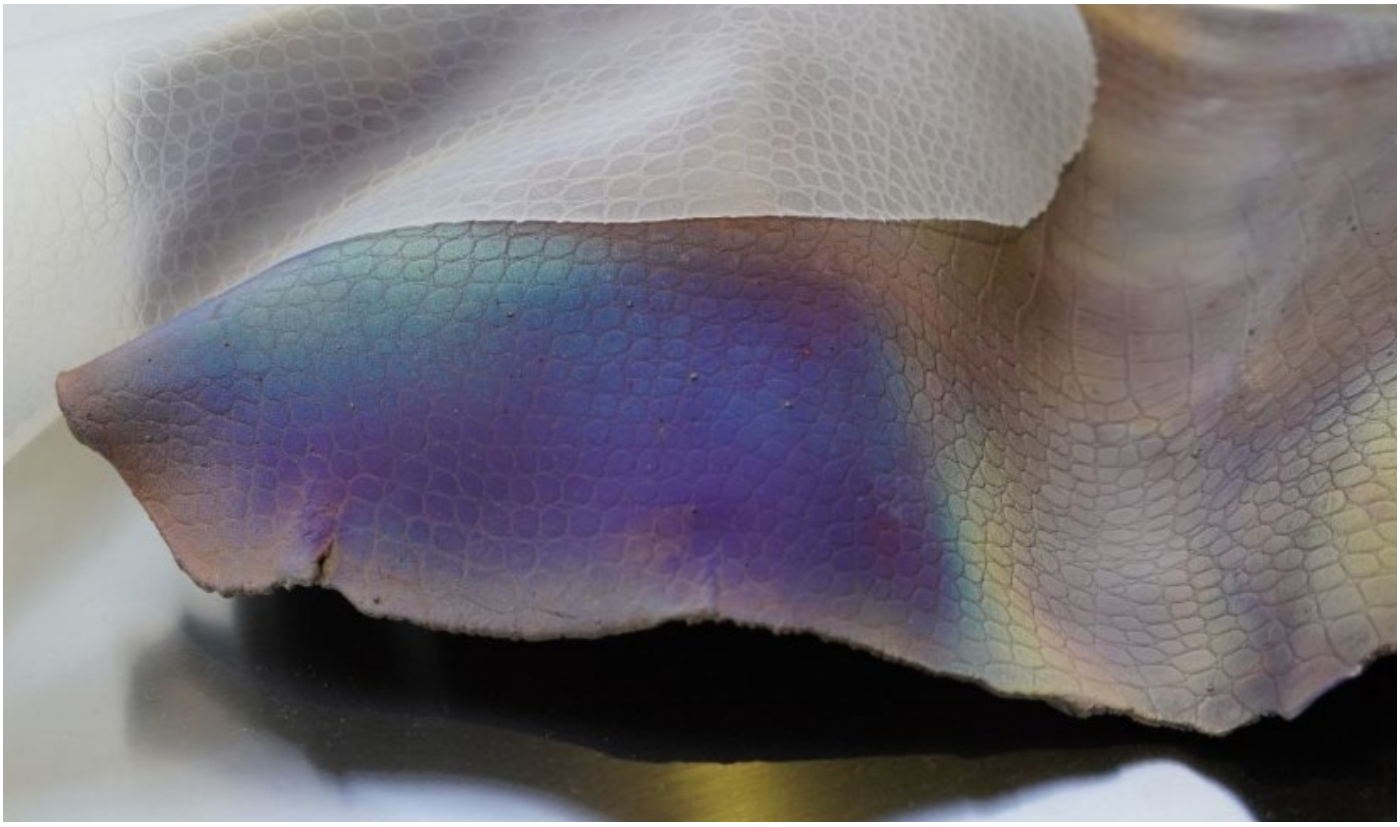


Image 11: Helene Kask, *Talismanic Bodies,* 2026.

Besides the silicone skins, I have also experimented with crafting skins in metal. In doing so, I have thought about historical metal armors designed to protect the body, a concept that aligns with the theme of protection in my project. While armor is not considered as conventional jewelry, it shares a profound connection to this context. Coming from a background in fashion design, I approach jewelry with the same mindset as I do with clothing, they share a strong kinship because both are defined by their relationship to a wearer. I view the body as a canvas, in dialogue with what it wears, transforming the body into a site of storytelling. Rather than restricting these practices to strict categories, I approach the boundaries between fashion, jewelry, and armor as fluid, thereby creating space for expansion and new creative processes. This fluid approach mirrors Haraway's arguments in "A Cyborg Manifesto", where she implies that we are in a *kinship* with everything around us, suggesting that we instead see our bodies as hybrid entities and extensions within all that surrounds us, from animals to machines.[15]

> Why should our bodies end at the skin, or include at the best, other beings encapsulated by skin?[16]

While researching the physiology of snakes, I learned they are masters of disguise, using camouflage to blend into their surroundings for protection and survival. A snake's skin is a complex architecture: it consists of stiff scales made of beta-keratin which protect the thin, elastic skin situated between them. When a snake sheds, it typically does so in one continuous piece.[17] All of these components I have played around with in my experiments. I have for instance worked with heat on the metal skins, to get different colour shadings. These shadings are in a constant state of ongoingness just by adding more or less heat, reacting and integrating with its surroundings, just like camouflage.

In this installation, I ask myself: have these skins already been shed, or are they about to be worn? Or can it be both? If the skins are considered armour, they could be reused when needed again, in a state of transformation and ongoingness.

[15] Donna Haraway, A Cyborg Manifesto: Science, Technology, and Socialist-Feminism in the Late Twentieth Century, in *Simians, Cyborgs, and Women: The Reinvention of Nature* (New York: Routledge, 1991), p. 220.
[16] Haraway, "A Cyborg Manifesto", p. 220.
[17] Sjöholm, *Ormarnas (Serpentes) Makroskopiska Anatomi*, p. 6.



Image 12: Helene Kask, *Talismanic Bodies,* 2025.



Image 13: Helene Kask, *Talismanic Bodies,* 2025.

Parallel to the making of the skins, I have crafted a large-scale steel structure. While working on this piece, I thought about skeletons: many individual steel pipes, or bones, as illustrated in the image to the left, adding up to a collective framework that protects and holds our bodies. I formed each individual pipe into new shapes, from straight to curved, using heat (as illustrated in the image to the right) and the weight of my own body. It was heavy labour that involved my entire physical being; but though the work was demanding, an act of care resided within the process as well. I find it poetic that my own body and skeleton have crafted new bodies and skeletons. At times, I felt like a surgeon in my Hybrid Laboratory, bending steel pipes into new forms. This process became an ongoing conversation with the metal, communicating through its materiality as it told me exactly when it could be altered. I learned to listen to the steel, and the steel responded to my actions. It became a making-with.

Through this process, I have reflected on a material's own agency and will, a concept Jane Bennett explores in *Vibrant Matter.*[18] She argues that metal is inherently *metallurgical:* an alloy shaped by biological, geological, and human forces. Bennett specifically discusses its *itinerant* nature, noting that metal is always in a state of becoming, sensitive to temperature, pressure, and chemical environments. I witness this itinerancy in the Hybrid Laboratory during my conversation with steel. This process proves that the metal is not a passive material, but an active, hybrid force possessed of its own agency. Bennett even suggests that we, as craftspersons, are actually shaped by the materials we handle.[19] This deeply resonates with my practice, as this has been my exact experience while working with steel.

This steel structure is in dialogue with the conceptual idea of shedding, yet it also transforms into something more: a framework or network where other elements can evolve. This is why this will be positioned at the centre of the installation. It exists in a state of ongoingness; because the structure is open, I can continuously add or remove pieces, altering its swirly loops and scale. It reminds me of the painting *Endosymbiosis* mentioned earlier, serving as a testament to symbiotic relations and assemblages. The structure represents a vast network of life, echoing Lynn Margulis's theories of endosymbiosis and manifesting in diverse forms, shapes, and constellations. It is a more-than-human metal body, a symbiotic organism. Another symbiotic organism that appears in this project will now be introduced in the following chapter.

[18] Jane Bennett, *Vibrant Matter: A Political Ecology of Things*, Durham, North Carolina: Duke University Press, 2010, p. 60.
[19] Bennett, *Vibrant Matter,* p. 60.

Conceptual idea no. 2

Organisms

Image 14: Helene Kask, *Talismanic Bodies,* 2026.

What if our bodies could code organisms in the future that would protect us from dangerous bacteria and viruses?

(The voice of scientist Leona)



Image 15: Aleris Graviditetsultraljud, *Ultrasound image of my son,* 2023.

This idea emerged at the Hagströmer Library, part of the Karolinska Institute, while examining their collection of medical amulets and talismans. Both have been used for protection historically and hold a significant place within the history of jewelry. They can be made from a wide range of materials, from found objects such as stones, animal parts and shells, to man-made items. The latter are usually crafted in metal with specific inscriptions and often carry deep symbolic, spiritual, or personal meanings. In ”A history of amulets in ten objects”, Annie Thwaite writes that they are: ”parts of a larger narrative of healing in which learned medicine, religion, astrology, magic, fate and fortune all play a role. As part of healing, objects could be invested with power from any or more of these various sources, and employed to cure or protect”.[20]

Inspired, I began investigating protective objects we might carry with(in) ourselves. Simultaneously, I visited the exhibition *Evigt liv* at Liljevalchs (2022), where I was intrigued by the display of the CRISPR/Cas9 genetic scissors. This is a ”molecular tool that can make precise incisions in genetic material, literally rewriting the code of life.”[21] I felt a deep connection to this technology since I was, at that time, navigating a parallel embodied narrative through IVF (In Vitro Fertilisation). The term *in vitro* means in glass, referring to the laboratory environment where fertilization occurs.[22] There was a certain irony in this: while science managed my physiological process in a medical lab, I was in the Hybrid Laboratory, using craft to investigate where a body begins and ends.

In ”A Cyborg Manifesto”, Donna Haraway argues that we are all already cyborgs stating that “modern medicine is full of cyborgs, of couplings between organism and machine.”[23] We inhabit this identity through everyday interventions, from contact lenses to pharmaceuticals, where the boundary between the natural and the artificial dissolves. For me, IVF was the ultimate expression of this condition. When I finally became pregnant on a hospital operating table, I watched the embryo on a screen as it was placed inside my body. This was a moment where my most intimate biological process was inseparable from scientific intervention. I was in the front row for this life-changing moment, feeling entirely like a cyborg. Through this experience, my body became a living laboratory for my artistic research, and I began reflecting on the relationship between the human and the machine, by which I mean the integration of science and technology.

[20] Annie Thwaite, ”A history of amulets in ten objects”, *Science Museum Group Journal,* issue 11, Spring 2019, https://journal.sciencemuseum.ac.uk/article/history-of-amulets/, 1 March 2026.
[21] The Nobelprize Organisation, *The Nobel Prize in Chemistry 2020,* https://www.nobelprize.org/prizes/chemistry/2020/popular-information/, 18 January 2026.
[22] Center for Reproductive Health & Gynecology, *Understanding the Miracle of In Vitro Fertilization,* https://www.reproductive.org/blog/ivf/, 1 March 2026.
[23] Donna Haraway, ”A Cyborg Manifesto”, p. 150.



Image 16: Helene Kask, *Talismanic Bodies,* 2023.



Image 17: Helene Kask, *Talismanic Bodies,* 2023.

Furthermore Haraway asks: "Who makes and who is made in the relationship between the hand and the machine?"[24] Seeking to explore this, I began Cyborg Crafting, investigating the materialization of digital data into physical life and craft, sculpting 3D shapes inspired by human anatomy, then 3D printing them as illustrated in the images above. In the book *Digital handmade*, the concept of the *digital artisan* is described. I found this closely aligned with my thoughts on cyborg crafting. It discusses how a digital artisan manipulates and merges advanced technologies with traditional tools. These results are combinations of hand and machine, creating new expressions that both challenge and develop craftsmanship and tradition.[25]

I knew I wanted to experiment with this hybrid way of making, combining the digital with traditional gold- and silversmithing techniques. However, the process of sculpting in a 3D program and 3D printing was, and still is, incredibly frustrating. While it offers incredible opportunities (for instance I made over 60 different sketches of organisms), it simultaneously holds me back. Often the visions in my mind could not be fully realized due to a lack of technical skills in the software. I want one thing; the machine wants another. It has become a true give-and-take relationship; the handmade and the machine-made creating together a symbiogenesis, a literal making-with the machine.

[24] Donna Haraway, "A Cyborg Manifesto", p. 175.
[25] Lucy Johnston, *Digital handmade: Craftmanship in the new Industrial Revolution,* New Edition, London, Thames & Hudson, 2017, p. 6-13.

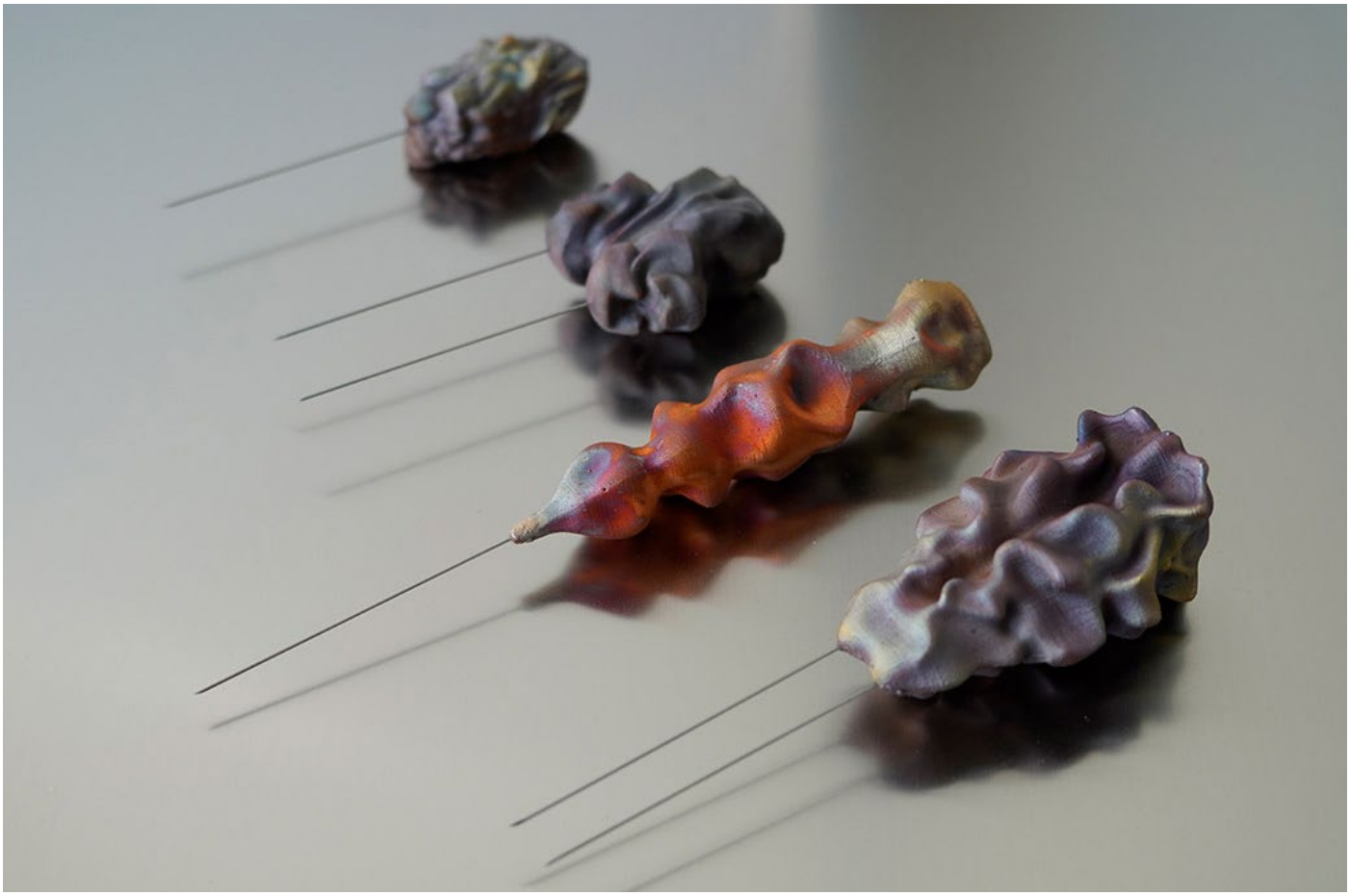


Image 18: Helene Kask, *Talismanic Bodies,* 2026.

The idea that we carry protective objects on or within ourselves as medical amulets felt interesting to explore. These organisms could be carried within us as microscopic entities, integrated into our bodies at a cellular level. They could also be carried on us/with us in the form of syringes, as illustrated on the image, that pierce the skin when activated, functioning just like a medical syringe. In this case, the method of attachment—penetrating the skin—references the traditional brooch, but instead of pinning to clothing, it anchors directly to the body. Both methods of wearing these jewelry pieces involve bodily modification and challenge traditional notions of wearability.

Two jewelry artists and postdoctoral researchers working with jewelry, science and technology in exciting new ways are Katharina Vones and Anneleen Swillen. Both challenge conventional views of traditional jewelry and wearability. Katharina Vones works with *smart materials,* meaning that something comes alive on the body when worn. Vones describes these as *symbiotic stimulus-reactive jewellery organisms.*[26] By exploring material science and wearable technologies, she seeks to blur the distinctions between craft and science. Anneleen Swillen explores jewelry, machine learning and data science amongst other things. In 2021, through the project *Artificial Intelligems*, jewelry artists were invited to submit images of their jewelry via an open call. These images were then altered through machine algorithms and AI to new, fluid, evolving images called *Ornamutations.*[27]

I find both examples inspiring because they integrate diverse disciplines, an approach I also aim to take. This is a path I certainly intend to explore and expand upon after graduation. The wordplay in both jewelry organism and ornamutation is highly innovative, as these terms suggest a multidisciplinary, cross-sectional way of thinking and making.

[26] Katharina Vones, *Towards the Posthuman: Materiality and process in the creation of stimulus-responsive jewellery objects,* PhD thesis, Edinburgh Napier University, 2017, p. 134, 18 January 2026.
[27] Anneleen Swillen and Greg Scheirlinck, *Ornamutations: Imagining Posthuman Jewellery?* Artificial Intelligems, 2021, https://artificialintelligems.com/ornamutations-since-2021/, 18 January 2026.

I wanted to continue with the life of these 3D-printed organisms through traditional gold- and silversmithing techniques as an ongoing process. I wondered: could I transform their material quality from plastic into a material that can be found biologically within our bodies, yet also relates to jewelry techniques? This led me to consider copper and the galvanic process. What is fascinating about copper is that it occurs naturally in our bodies and is a vital component of our skeleton and immune system.[28] It is very much a vibrant matter.

The image in the background shows the electroplating bath in the Hybrid Laboratory's chemical room. The galvanic process that takes place here, also known as electroplating, is a method where a metal coating is added to an object, in this case, a piece of jewelry. Several players are involved here in a symbiotic relationship with each other. There is the giver (the anode) which is the positive pole, this could be a copper plate, for example. Then there is the receiver (the cathode) the negative pole, which is the jewelry piece to which you want to add metal. Both are placed into a liquid called an electrolyte. When an electrical current passes through the bath, metal ions dissolves into the electrolyte and move toward the negative electrode, building up metallic layers on the jewelry piece.[29]

The thickness of the coating can be adjusted based on how long the piece remains in the bath, the longer the duration, the thicker the layers. This process is interesting from a philosophical perspective because it represents relational making. It is making-with and becoming-with, shaping new life and expressions born out of cooperation. Again, a dancing conversation between different players in a posthuman and more-than-human context. This process can also be reversed: if the current flows in the other direction, the jewelry piece dissolves and the metal plate receives. Thus, no player in this process is superior to the other, they can both give and receive in a world-building of listening, learning, and care-taking for each other.

[28] MedicalNewsToday, *Health benefits and risks of copper,* https://www.medicalnewstoday.com/articles/288165/, 18 January 2026.
[29] Jewelry Technology Forum, *Introduction: the galvanic process,* https://jtf.it/en/memories/2019/introduction-the-galvanic-process/, 18 January 2026.

Image 19: Helene Kask, *Image from the Hybrid Laboratory,* 2026.

After the electroplating I have, once again, experimented with heat, as illustrated on image, to draw out the copper's inherent qualities. The copper organisms appear deeply corporeal; by adding heat and creating various colour shadings, they began to remind me of bacterial growth in petri dishes, acting as an embodiment of living matter.

For the exhibition, I aim to display these organisms on a hanging steel sheet, creating the sensation that they are almost floating in the room. I plan to present them alongside a mouth-blown glass object to refer to the conceptual idea of a petri dish and bacterial growth. This also serves as a reference to the term in vitro mentioned at the beginning of this chapter, meaning in glass, referencing the laboratory environment where fertilization occurs.

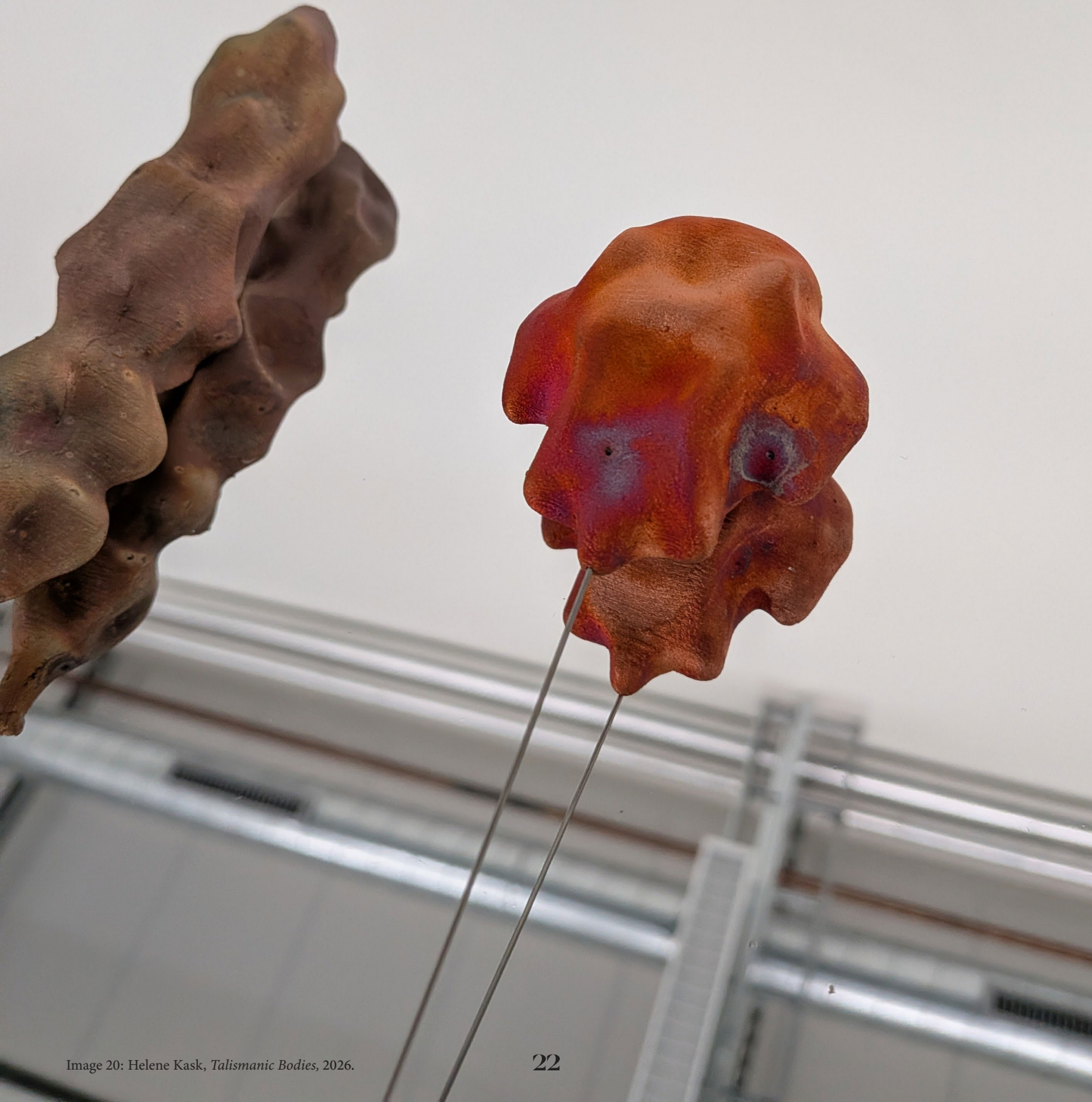


Image 20: Helene Kask, *Talismanic Bodies,* 2026.



Conceptual idea no. 3

Liquid Gold

Image 21: Helene Kask, *Talismanic Bodies,* 2025.

What if our bodies could feed themselves in the future through an internal system if we run out of food or water?

(The voice of the Hybrid Laboratory)

When I started breastfeeding my child, I was completely amazed by my body's capacity to produce food for another human being. I was struck by the fact that it instantly becomes a feedback loop, as the feeding itself triggers milk production, a food circle from body to body.

The first breast milk produced is called *colostrum*, also known as liquid gold. As a craftist and new mother, I thought this name was brilliant for two reasons. First, gold is a commonly used material in the traditional jewelry context. Second, is the connection to alchemy and the pursuit of transforming base metals into gold. While I will not delve deeply into the world of alchemy in this paper, much as I would love to, it remains a relevant connection. From a biological perspective, colostrum is called liquid gold not only for its yellowish colour but for its immense health benefits. It is packed with proteins, fats, carbohydrates, vitamins, minerals, and antibodies, providing the newborn with concentrated nutrition and a vital boost to the immune system.[30]

I started thinking, what if our bodies could feed themselves in the future, through an internal system? In this context, I find Stacy Alaimo's thoughts on *trans-corporeality* interesting. This is a place where corporeal theories and environmental theories meet and expand together. Alaimo argues that humans are inseparable from nature and the environment through the acts of breathing, eating and absorbing. "Nature is always as close as one's skin." We are *intermeshed* with the world of *fleshy beings.*[31]

Indeed, we are in a constant connection with everything surrounding us, and I wanted this system to reflect that, becoming a feedback loop in constant dialogue with the air we breathe, the birds that sing, the trees that whisper, and the bacteria that coexist with us. I began making a bodily system that operates on the inside of our bodies, as an integrated part of the body. A system that loops and circulates, providing us with a nutritional fluid, a liquid gold, containing everything we need for survival.

[30] Medela, *Varför är colostrum så viktigt?,* https://www.medela.com/sv-se/amningspumpning/artiklar/brostmjolkens-fordelar/varfor-ar-colostrum-sa-viktigt/, 1 March 2026.
[31] Stacy Alaimo, "Trans-corporeal Feminisms", in *Material Feminisms*, edited by Stacy Alaimo & Susan Hekman, Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2008, p. 237–238.



Image 22: Helene Kask, *Talismanic Bodies,* 2022.



Image 23: Helene Kask, *Talismanic Bodies,* 2022.

The cyclic shape is a central aspect of this piece, as I wanted to investigate a system that recycles. Furthermore, the cyclic shape, the ring, is also a commonly used shape in jewelry, appearing as rings on fingers, piercings for body modifications or links in chains.

This jewelry piece is constructed from a silicone tube connected in a circle (illustrated in the image to the right), and silver rings assembled using the traditional jewelry technique of chain mail. This method involves connecting rings in different combinations to create diverse chains (example of chain mail on image to the left). Historically, chain mail was used to create protective armour, where rings were assembled into a mesh-like structure that functioned almost like a metal fabric. This function is still used today, for example, in specialized gloves used to protect against animal bites. The fact that this jewelry technique has historically been used for protective purposes mirrors the core intent of this project.

From a philosophical perspective, these links are ongoing and relational; one attaches to another in a series of events, each reacting to the other. They are all parts of a co-generated process, a network of relations and a continuous, non-linear process of becoming.

In the exhibition context this jewelry system will be displayed on top of a hanging light box featuring an X-ray scan of a chest, indicating that this jewelry piece is intended for the inside of the body. It will be possible for visitors to stand in front or behind the light box and wear the piece, as it will be hanging at the height of a human body.

Conclusion

How can jewelry function as a speculative method to examine possible futuristic scenarios and explore different bodily protective qualities we may require to survive?

In my master's project, Talismanic Bodies, I have explored this research question through a conceptual and theoretical framework I call Speculative Craft. This work has been a journey through imagination and dreaming, but also through posthuman and more-than-human ways of thinking. As a Craftist I have used jewelry as a method for artistic exploration. Much of this research took place within the Hybrid Laboratory, a space with immense potential in the future. Not only as my personal creative studio but as a hub for co-creation and interdisciplinary collaborative work across fields like science and technology.

Throughout this paper, I investigate how jewelry can work as a speculative method to explore the futures and what we might need for survival. Through three conceptual ideas, these jewelry pieces ask questions rather then provide answers. They suggest possibilities while remaining open and fluid, leaving space for the viewer's own reflections. They exist in a state of ongoingness, extractions of speculative research without a defined beginning or end. They may seem impossible, they challenge us to expand our thinking regarding future possibilities, acting as catalyst for necessary expansion.

I have realized that I can use jewelry as a method to critically discuss diverse topics, addressing our planet's current trajectory and suggesting alternative, more symbiotic futures inspired by the theories of Donna Haraway and Lynn Margulis. By challenging traditional notions of wearability, I move away from decorative adornment toward jewelry that is integrated with(in) our bodies, becoming speculative life forms. By employing hybrid ways of thinking, these jewelry pieces become acts of resistance, challenging both what is and what could be. I believe this type of craft is essential in our current world.

A symbiotic approach to future life and making has been fundamental to my work. A significant discovery has been the realization that the materials I work with are vibrant matters. I have been in conversations with these materials throughout this process, we have co-created this project together.

Another significant discovery that emerged, one I did not anticipate in the beginning, was my personal transition into motherhood. Navigating through IVF and breastfeeding turned my body into a living laboratory for my research, shifting from abstract speculative scenarios, to a grounded cyborg reality, deepening this projects intent.

The project consists of three conceptual ideas presented as an installation. Each could be a stand-alone project, as there is still so much to discover. Deciding which ideas to finalize has been a challenge, but it has also highlighted the project's long-term potential. I have only scratched the surface and intend to continue this research after graduation by collaborating with scientific laboratories, I believe this type of exchange would be beneficial for both and we could share ideas, learn and expand together. But I also aim to collaborate with other artists that work with similar subjects as myself.

Working with metal in a larger scale for the first time presented another significant challenge. Bending and polishing every steel pipe myself was physically demanding. However, the process has been rewarding, since I was engaged in a deep conversation and co-creation with materiality, and I plan to continue working with this scale in the future.

As the exhibition approaches, I am still conducting experiments in my Hybrid Laboratory. In each chapter, I have outlined my aims for the exhibition; however, as the work is ongoing, these details may change. I envision the exhibition as a speculative experience where the viewer can wear internal jewelry and physically position themselves within these speculative futures. By bridging the gap between jewelry and science, I believe this project contributes to the field of craft by expanding the understanding of what a piece of jewelry can be: not just a decorative object, but a meeting point between the human body and a speculative future environment. A symbiotic interface for survival.

As we stand at this threshold.
I invite you to close your eyes for a moment.
Take a deep breath.

Place yourself somewhere in the future.

What do you see?
How does the wind feel against your skin?
What does the air smell like?
What do you hear?
Are you warm or cold?

Now, I want you to consider:
What protective quality do you wish you possessed?
In your speculative future?
In order to survive?

This project is dedicated to my son and the future us.

Bibliography

Books

Alaimo, Stacy, ”Trans-corporeal Feminisms”, in *Material Feminisms,* edited by Stacy Alaimo & Susan Hekman, Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2008.

Bennett, Jane, *Vibrant Matter: A Political Ecology of Things,* Durham, North Carolina: Duke University Press, 2010.

Dunne, Anthony & Raby, Fiona, *Speculative Everything: Design, Fiction, and Social Dreaming,* Massachusetts: The Mit Press, 2013.

Haraway Donna, ”A Cyborg Manifesto: Science, Technology, and Socialist-Feminism in the Late Twentieth Century”, in *Simians, Cyborgs, and Women: The Reinvention of Nature,* New York: Routledge, 1991.

Haraway, Donna, *Staying with the Trouble: Making Kin in the Chthulucene,* Durham, North Carolina: Duke University Press, 2016.

Johnston, Lucy, *Digital handmade: Craftsmanship in the new Industrial Revolution,* New edition London, Thames & Hudson, 2017.

Margulis, Lynn, *The Symbiotic Planet: A New Look at Evolution,* London: The Orion Publishing Group Ltd, 1998.

Tsing, Anna, Heather Swanson, Elaine Gan & Nils Bubandt, eds., *Arts of Living on a Damaged Planet: Ghosts and Monsters of the Anthropocene,* Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2017.

PhD Dissertation/Thesis & Master Thesis (accessed online)

Sjöholm, Matilda, *Ormarnas (Serpentes) makroskopiska anatomi,* Master’s Thesis, University of Helsinki, 2018, https://helda.helsinki.fi/items/22998970-c485-4bbe-ba4d-a4757fdfb36e/full/, 1 March 2026.

Vones, Katharina, *Towards the Posthuman: Materiality and process in the creation of stimulus-responsive jewellery objects,* PhD Thesis, Edinburgh Napier University, 2017, https://napier-repository.worktribe.com/output/412551/, 1 March 2026.

Academic Journals (accessed online)

Thwaite Annie, ”A history of amulets in ten objects”, *Science Museum Group Journal,* issue 11, Spring 2019, https://journal.sciencemuseum.ac.uk/article/history-of-amulets/, 1 March 2026.

Bibliography

Online Sources

Center for Reproductive Health & Gynecology, *Understanding the Miracle of In Vitro Fertilization,* https://www.reproductive.org/blog/ivf/, 1 March 2026.

Favan, Loan, *ALLIAGE -Cu29Zn30,* Naula Studio, https://www.naulastudio.com/Alliage-Cu29Zn30/, 1 March 2026.

Hess, Bart, *About,* https://www.barthess.com/about/, 1 March 2026.

Jewelry Technology Forum, *Introduction: the galvanic process,* https://jtf.it/en/memories/2019/introduction-the-galvanic-process/, 18 January 2026.

Liu, Ani, *Hello,* https://ani-liu.com/hello/, 1 March 2026.

McRae, Lucy, *Home,* https://www.lucymcrae.net/, 1 March 2026.

McRae, Lucy & Bart Hess, *LucyandBart,* https://www.lucymcrae.net/lucyandbart/, 1 March 2026.

Medela, *Varför är colostrum så viktigt?,* https://www.medela.com/sv-se/amningspumpning/artiklar/brostmjolkens-fordelar/varfor-ar-colostrum-sa-viktigt/, 1 March 2026.

MedicalNewsToday, *Health benefits and risks of copper,* https://www.medicalnewstoday.com/articles/288165/, 18 January 2026.

Mellish, Ruby, *About,* https://rubymellish.com/ABOUT/, 1 March 2026.

Merry, James, *About,* https://jtmerry.com/pages/about/, 1 March 2026.

Rajcevic, Ana, *Ana Rajcevic,* MIT Center for Art, Science & Technology, https://arts.mit.edu/people/ana-rajcevic/, 1 March 2026.

Swillen, Anneleen & Greg Scheirlinck, *Ornamutations: Imagining Posthuman Jewellery?,* Artificial Intelligems, 2021, https://artificialintelligems.com/ornamutations-since-2021/, 18 January 2026.

The Nobel Prize Organisation, *The Nobel Prize in Chemistry 2020,* https://www.nobelprize.org/prizes/chemistry/2020/popular-information/, 18 January 2026.

Van Herpen, Iris, *About Iris van Herpen,* https://www.irisvanherpen.com/about/iris-van-herpen/, 1 March 2026.

Digital articles/interviews

Benzine, Vittoria, *How Tobias Gremmler is Bringing Björk's Utopian Nature to Life,* Dazed, 21 November 2019, https://www.dazeddigital.com/beauty/article/46893/1/bjork-tobias-gremmler-nature-digital-art-artist-cornucopia-tour/, 1 March 2026.

Levy, Hannah, *Hannah Levy's bulbous, bulging bodies,* Plaster Magazine, 29 May 2024, https://plastermagazine.com/interviews/hannah-levy-bulge-interview/, 1 March 2026.

List of images

Image 1. NASA, *Bubble Nebula* [photography], 1990, https://images.nasa.gov/details/GSFC-20171208-Archive-e000383/, [28 February 2026]

Image 2. NASA, Ames Research Center, *Space Colony Art: Stanford Torus Interior* [photography], 1975, https://images.nasa.gov/details/ARC-1975-AC75-0027/, [28 February 2026]

Image 3. Kask, Helene, *Talismanic Bodies* [process image], 2022, Konstfack, Stockholm.

Image 4. Dubiner, Shoshana, *Endosymbiosis* [painting], 2012, https://www.cybermuse.com/blog/2012/2/13/endosymbiosis-homage-to-lynn-margulis.html/, [1 March 2026]

Image 5. Kask, Helene, *Talismanic Bodies* [process image], 2022, Konstfack, Stockholm.

Image 6. Kask, Helene, *Talismanic Bodies* [process image], 2025, Konstfack, Stockholm.

Image 7. Kask, Helene, *Talismanic Bodies* [process image], 2025, Konstfack, Stockholm.

Image 8. Kask, Helene, *Talismanic Bodies* [process image], 2022, Konstfack, Stockholm.

Image 9. Kask, Helene, *Talismanic Bodies* [process image], 2022, Konstfack, Stockholm.

Image 10. Kask, Helene, *Talismanic Bodies* [process image], 2022, Konstfack, Stockholm.

Image 11. Kask, Helene, *Talismanic Bodies* [process image], 2026, Konstfack, Stockholm.

Image 12. Kask, Helene, *Talismanic Bodies* [process image], 2026, Konstfack, Stockholm.

Image 13. Kask, Helene, *Talismanic Bodies* [process image], 2026, Konstfack, Stockholm.

Image 14. Kask, Helene, *Talismanic Bodies* [jewelry], 2026, Konstfack, Stockholm.

Image 15. Aleris Graviditetsultraljud, *Ultrasound image of my son* [ultrasound scan], 2023, Stock holm.

Image 16. Kask, Helene, *Talismanic Bodies* [process image], 2023, Konstfack, Stockholm.

Image 17. Kask, Helene, *Talismanic Bodies* [process image], 2023, Konstfack, Stockholm.

Image 18. Kask, Helene, *Talismanic Bodies* [jewelry], 2026, Konstfack, Stockholm.

Image 19. Kask, Helene, *Image from the Hybrid Laboratory* [process image], 2026, Konstfack, Stockholm.

Image 20. Kask, Helene, *Talismanic Bodies* [jewelry], 2026, Konstfack, Stockholm.

Image 21. Kask, Helene, *Talismanic Bodies* [process image], 2025, Konstfack, Stockholm.

Image 22. Kask, Helene, *Talismanic Bodies* [process image], 2022, Konstfack, Stockholm.

List of images

Image 23. Kask, Helene, *Talismanic Bodies* [process image], 2025, Konstfack, Stockholm.

Image 24. Favan, Loan, *Alliage-Cu29Zn30.* [jewelry], 2020, https://www.naulastudio.com/Alliage-Cu29Zn30/, [1 March 2026]

Image 25. Favan, Loan, *Alliage-Cu29Zn30.* [jewelry], 2020, https://www.naulastudio.com/Alliage-Cu29Zn30/, [1 March 2026]

Image 26. Liu, Ani, *Microbial Selt Portraits* [sculpture/installation], 2022, https://ani-liu.com/kisses-from-the-future/, [1 March 2026]

Image 27. Liu, Ani, *Untitled (Labor of Love)* [installation], 2022, https://ani-liu.com/untitled-labor-of-love/, [1 March 2026]

Image 28. Hess, Bart, *Mutants* [body sculpture], 2011, https://www.barthess.com/mutants/, [1 March 2026]

Image 29. Hess, Bart, *Grotto* [sculpture/installation], 2014, https://www.barthess.com/grotto/, [1 March 2026]

Image 30. McRae, Lucy, *Swallowable Parfum* [still image from film], 2011, https://www.lucymcrae.net/swallowable-parfum/, [1 March 2026]

Image 31. McRae, Lucy, *Make your Maker* [still image from film], 2012, https://www.lucymcrae.net/make-your-maker/, [1 March 2026]

Image 32. McRae, Lucy & Hess Bart, *LucyandBart* [body sculpture], 2007-2009, https://www.lucymcrae.net/lucyandbart/, [1 March 2026]

Image 33. McRae, Lucy & Hess Bart, *LucyandBart* [body sculpture], 2007-2009, https://www.lucymcrae.net/lucyandbart/, [1 March 2026]

Image 34. Herpen, Iris, *Sensory Seas* [couture outfit/jewelry], 2020, https://www.irisvanherpen.com/collections/sensory-seas/sensory-seas-photography-by-molly-sj-lowe/, [1 March 2026]

Image 35. Herpen, Iris, *Syntopia* [couture jewelry], 2018, https://www.irisvanherpen.com/collections/syntopia/editorial-5/, [1 March 2026]

Image 36. Gremmler, Tobias, *Untitled (Shared Skin)* [digital image], 2021, https://www.instagram.com/p/CSC-ySkjDWw/?img-index=2&igsh=bmI2bHg4bDV1bzR3/, [1 March 2026]

Image 37. Gremmler, Tobias & Björk, *Tabula Rasa* [still image from music video], 2024, https://www.instagram.com/p/DDxLDLHNRpA/?igsh=eXh1dDZmMGd3M21h&img-index=2/, [1 March 2026]

Image 38. Mellish, Ruby, *Narcissus - Pessimist* [jewelry], 2021, https://rubymellish.com/PESSIMIST/, [1 March 2026]

List of images

Image 39. Mellish, Ruby, *Narcissus - Pessimist* [jewelry], 2021, https://rubymellish.com/SPECULAR/, [1 March 2026.]

Image 40. Rajcevic, Ana, *Animal: The Other Side of Evolution* [body sculpture], 2012, https://www.instagram.com/p/DBJjDaVvipq/?igsh=MWlwaTljMDE0dG94bQ%3D%3D [1 March 2026]

Image 41. Rajcevic, Ana, *Solid Ground* [body sculpture], 2022, https://www.instagram.com/p/C0Ty1ePsAXS/?igsh=MWE4ZXFpaGE0MG1zeA== [1 March 2026]

Image 42. Merry, James, *The Sulis mask* [face mask], 2025, https://www.instagram.com/p/DN-XgKZgiSY/?igsh=MWdscXB6NjQ2bjhh [1 March 2026]

Image 43. Merry, James, *The Alopex mask* [face mask], 2022, https://www.instagram.com/p/Ci2Ra-FDSjM/?img-index=5&igsh=MXFkNDNhZHV5dT [1 March 2026]

Image 44. Levy, Hannah, *Untitled* [sculpture], 2025, https://hannahslevy.com/project/work/HL2025-002-06.jpg/, [1 March 2026]

Image 45. Levy, Hannah, *Untitled* [sculpture], 2020, https://hannahslevy.com/project/work/HL2020-001-19.jpg/, [1 March 2026]

Image 46. Kask, Helene, *Talismanic Bodies: Shedding* [sculpture], 2026, Konstfack, Stockholm.

Image 47. Kask, Helene, *Talismanic Bodies: Shedding* [sculpture], 2026, Konstfack, Stockholm.

Image 48. Kask, Helene, *Talismanic Bodies: Shedding* [sculpture], 2026, Konstfack, Stockholm.

Image 49. Kask, Helene, *Talismanic Bodies: Shedding* [sculpture], 2026, Konstfack, Stockholm.

Image 50. Kask, Helene, *Talismanic Bodies: Organisms* [jewelry], 2026, Konstfack, Stockholm.

Image 51. Kask, Helene, *Talismanic Bodies: Organisms* [jewelry], 2026, Konstfack, Stockholm.

Image 52. Kask, Helene & Holden, Luke (glass object), *Talismanic Bodies: Organisms* [jewelry & glass object], 2026, Konstfack, Stockholm.

Image 53. Kask, Helene & Holden, Luke (glass object), *Talismanic Bodies: Organisms* [jewelry & glass object], 2026, Konstfack, Stockholm.

Image 54. Kask, Helene, *Talismanic Bodies: Liquid Gold* [jewelry], 2026, Konstfack, Stockholm.

Image 55. Kask, Helene, *Talismanic Bodies: Liquid Gold* [jewelry], 2026, Konstfack, Stockholm.

Appendix - contextual references

I have curated a collection of artistic and contextual references in the appendix, envisioning it as a library of inspirations. Each of these artists works in a way that resonates with my own creative process and the theoretical framework of this project.

Loan Favan

A jewelry designer who works with speculation. Drawing on themes of transhumanism, this collection reimagines jewelry as wearable superpowers designed for a posthuman future.[32]



Image 24: Loan Favan, *Alliage-Cu29Zn30*, 2020.

Image 25: Loan Favan, *Alliage-Cu29Zn30*, 2020.

Ani Liu

A research-based artist working at the intersection of art & science. Her work examines reproduction and motherhood, but has also explored microorganisms in the body.[33]



Image 26: Ani Liu, *Microbial Self Portraits,* 2015-2022.

Image 27: Ani Liu, *Untitled (Labor of love),* 2022.

[32] Loan Favan, *ALLIAGE -Cu29Zn30,* Naula Studio, https://www.naulastudio.com/Alliage-Cu29Zn30/, 1 March 2026.
[33] Ani Liu, *Hello,* https://ani-liu.com/hello/, 1 March 2026.

Bart Hess

A tactile artist who explores materials in relation to the human body. I am especially intrigued by his experimentation with skin as a medium, creating a tension between the physical body and the material.[34]



Image 28. Bart Hess, *Mutants,* 2011.

Image 29. Bart Hess, *Grotto,* 2014.

Lucy McRae

A *body architect* and *science fiction artist*, who explores the future of human existence, by blurring the boundaries between biology and technology through provocative films, sculptures, and immersive installations.[35]



Image 30. Lucy McRae, *Swallowable Parfum,* 2011.

Image 31. Lucy McRae, *Make your Maker,* 2012.

[34] Bart Hess, *About (Bart Hess)*, https://www.barthess.com/about/, 1 March 2026.
[35] Lucy McRae, *Home (Lucy McRae)*, https://www.lucymcrae.net/, 1 March 2026.

LucyandBart

This is a photographic collaboration between Lucy and Bart Hess, investigating the human silhuette might look in the future.[36]



Image 32. LucyandBart, *Untitled,* 2007-2009.

Image 33. LucyandBart, *Untitled,* 2007-2009.

Iris van Herpen

A pioneering fashion designer who merges traditional couture with innovative technologies like 3D printing, exploring the human body, nature, and science.[37]



Image 34. Iris van Herpen, *Sensory Seas,* 2020.

Image 35. Iris van Herpen, *Syntopia,* 2018.

[36] Lucy McRae and Bart Hess, *LucyandBart (Lucy McRae)*, https://www.lucymcrae.net/lucyandbart/, 1 March 2026.
[37] Iris van Herpen, *About Iris van Herpen (Iris van Herpen),* https://www.irisvanherpen.com/about/iris-van-herpen/, 1 March 2026.

Tobias Gremler

A digital artist who transforms bodies beyond physical limits through technology. Inspired by nature he explores metamorphosis, an exploration showcased in his collaboration with the artist Björk.[38]



Image 36. Tobias Gremler, *Untitled (Shared Skin),* 2021.

Image 37. Tobias Gremler & Björk, *Tabula Rasa,* 2024.

Ruby Mellish

A jewelry designer who, inspired by the human body and digital manipulation, creates surreal new realities that challenge the boundaries of the physical body.[39]



Image 38. Ruby Mellish, *Narcissus - Pessimist,* 2021.

Image 39. Ruby Mellish, *Narcissus - Specular,* 2021.

[38] Vittoria Benzine, *How Tobias Gremmler is Bringing Björk's Utopian Nature to Life,* Dazed, 21 November 2019, https://www.dazeddigital.com/beauty/article/46893/1/bjork-tobias-gremmler-nature-digital-art-artist-cornucopia-tour/, 1 March 2026.

[39] Ruby Mellish, *About,* https://rubymellish.com/RUBY-MELLISH/, 1 March 2026.

Ana Rajcevic

Working at the intersection of art and science, her research-led practice explores new modes of embodiment via hybrid prosthetics and animal-like bodily extensions.[40]



Image 40. Ana Rajcevic, *Animal: The Other Side of Evolution,* 2012.

Image 41. Ana Rajcevic, *Solid ground,* 2022.

James Merry

A visual artist known for his masks, frequently worn by the artist Björk, and his intricate hand embroideries. He blends traditional craft techniques with modern technology, such as 3D printing and digital face filters.[41]



Image 42. James Merry, *The Alopex mask,* 2022.

Image 43. James Merry, *The Sulis mask,* 2025.

[40] Ana Rajcevic, *Ana Rajcevic (MIT Center for Art, Science & Technology)*, https://arts.mit.edu/people/ana-rajcevic/, 1 March 2026.
[41] James Merry, *About (James Merry)*, https://jtmerry.com/pages/about/, 1 March 2026.

Hannah Levy

Levy works with sculptures made of steel and glass; I am intrigued by how she succeeds in making these industrial materials appear so soft and organic. Her practice of combining these elements with silicone is particularly interesting, as she notes: ”I like to create objects that have anthropomorphic or bodily elements.”[42]



Image 44. Hannah Levy, *Untitled,* 2025.

Image 45. Hannah Levy, *Untitled,* 2020.

[42] Hannah Levy, *Hannah Levy's bulbous, bulging bodies,* (Plaster Magazine, 29 May 2024, https://plastermagazine.com/interviews/hannah-levy-bulge-interview/, 1 March 2026.

Appendix - reflection

The following section presents a reflection on the examination exhibition, the discussion with the opponents, and the spring exhibition.

Conceptual and theoretical frameworks
The most significant realization for me within this project is that the theoretical and contextual frameworks are just as important as the making and the jewelry themselves; they are, in themselves, pieces of art. At the beginning of my Master's, I envisioned creating a book or publication featuring my discussions, reflections, and conclusions to present alongside the jewelry pieces. This did not happen due to a lack of understanding of just how important this context is in relation to the finished pieces. Looking back, this contextual writing is exactly what I feel is missing when I present my work in an exhibition setting.

During my examination and opponent discussion, the conversation centered on my theoretical and conceptual frameworks rather than the physical jewelry pieces exhibited in Havet. At the time, I felt somewhat disappointed that the conversation did not focus more on my craftsmanship. However, reflecting on it now, I realize that my physical pieces do not fully communicate my intent without their underlying thoughts. Visually, the objects are simply not as strong on their own, my work requires this secondary narrative layer to be present.

This presents a great challenge: how can I weave complex theories into the viewer's experience within an exhibition context in a way that feels accessible? Instead of viewing this as a shortcoming, I see it as a great opportunity. My work actively provokes theoretical discussion, which I believe is often missing from the contemporary jewelry context today. Moving forward, excerpts from my thesis are set for publication this autumn across multiple platforms, and I will continue to investigate the integration of making and writing, using it as both an artistic method, but also as an experiment in how conceptual frameworks and physical objects can coexist in visual presentations.

The presence and use of speculative voices, the alter egos described in this project, was another point of feedback I received during my examination in relation to the frameworks. It was noted that these voices hold great potential and could even be considered as scripts that carry these different imaginary narratives. The sense of a presence in my installation is a quality my work naturally evokes, and it is something that could be enhanced and explored further. I have considered working both with film and audio, paths I did not pursue this time around, but where I see great potential going forward. As a creative methodology, I can see these voices guiding me in future exhibition contexts, functioning just as they do when I channel them in my writing, allowing me to be more fluid and let go of control.

The presentation
Another reflection raised during my examination was that my installation looks highly clinical, and that it could have benefited from displaying more process-based experiments to enhance the laboratory concept. I completely agree with this observation, which I had also made myself during the installation of the examination exhibition. Early on, my vision was to create a setting that resembled an actual laboratory, showcasing numerous experiments and material investigations, an environment closer to the one I describe in the introduction of the Hybrid Laboratory. This is an approach I will experiment with in the future.

Furthermore, I have realized that the white cube format is not the optimal environment for my work. Instead, I envision my pieces integrated within spaces that directly relate to the themes and frameworks I explore. For instance, if they were exhibited in the Hagströmer Library in Stockholm or the Museum of Medical History (Medicinhistoriska museet) in Uppsala, spaces embedded with scientific history, the narrative would be strengthened and read in a completely different way.

Ultimately, my work lives in the tension between the cold, clinical nature of science and the vulnerable intimacy of the human body. It is a delicate balance, and one I am constantly pushing and challenging. Viewers from both of the recent exhibitions have shared the same reaction: my pieces evoke both beauty and fear. This is interesting to me, as it captures the exact feelings I carry toward our future. I find a great power in this threshold, and it expands my work, transforming jewelry objects into portals to spaces where dreams and reality blur, fusing into new worlds that are as breathtaking as they are terrifying.

Following, you will find images from the examination and spring exhibition.



Image 46. Helene Kask, *Talismanic Bodies: Shedding,* 2026.



Image 47. Helene Kask, *Talismanic Bodies: Shedding,* 2026.

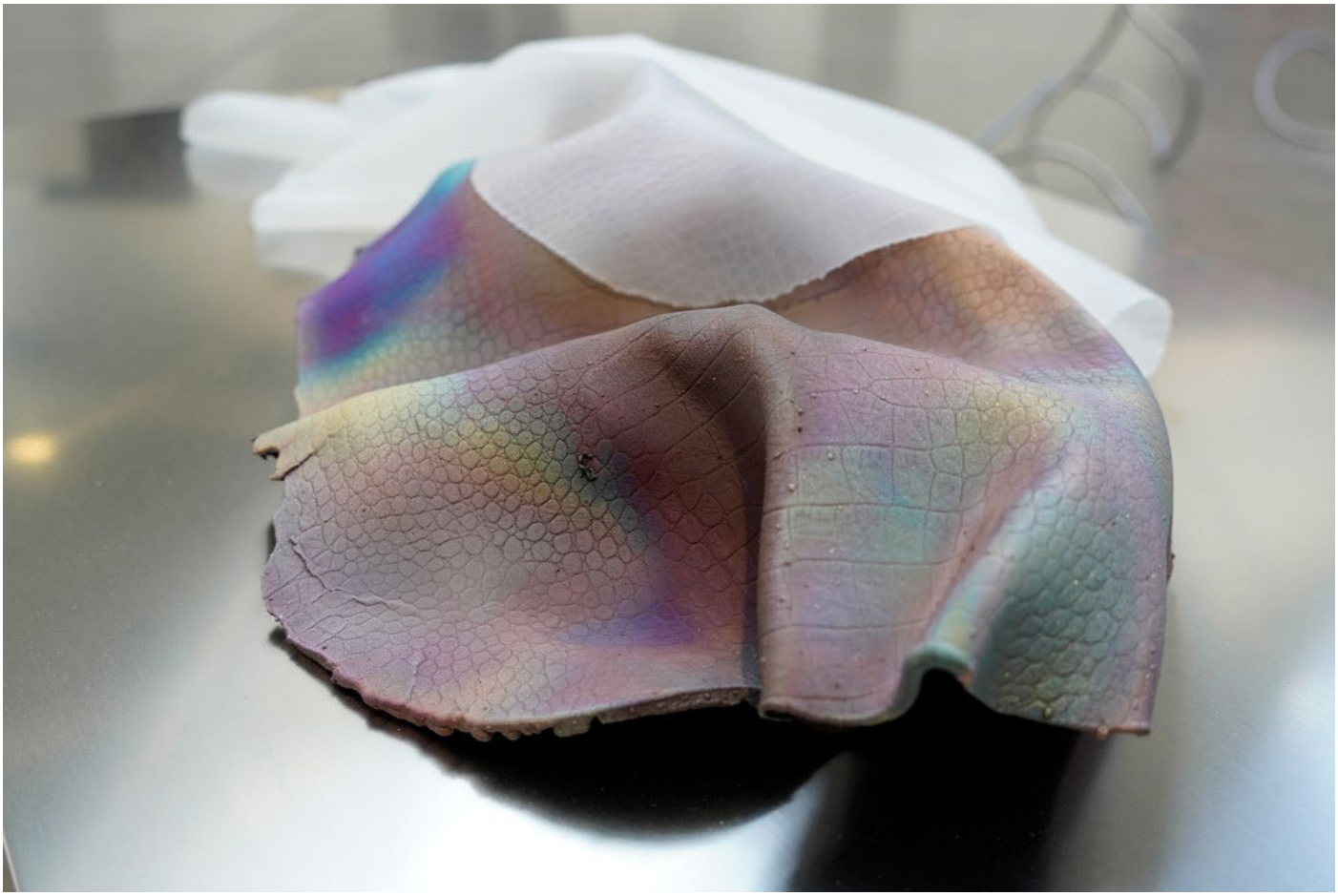


Image 48. Helene Kask, *Talismanic Bodies: Shedding,* 2026.



Image 49. Helene Kask, *Talismanic Bodies: Shedding,* 2026.



Image 50. Helene Kask, *Talismanic Bodies: Organisms,* 2026.



Image 51. Helene Kask, *Talismanic Bodies: Organisms,* 2026.



Image 52. Helene Kask & Luke Holden (glass object), *Talismanic Bodies: Organisms,* 2026.

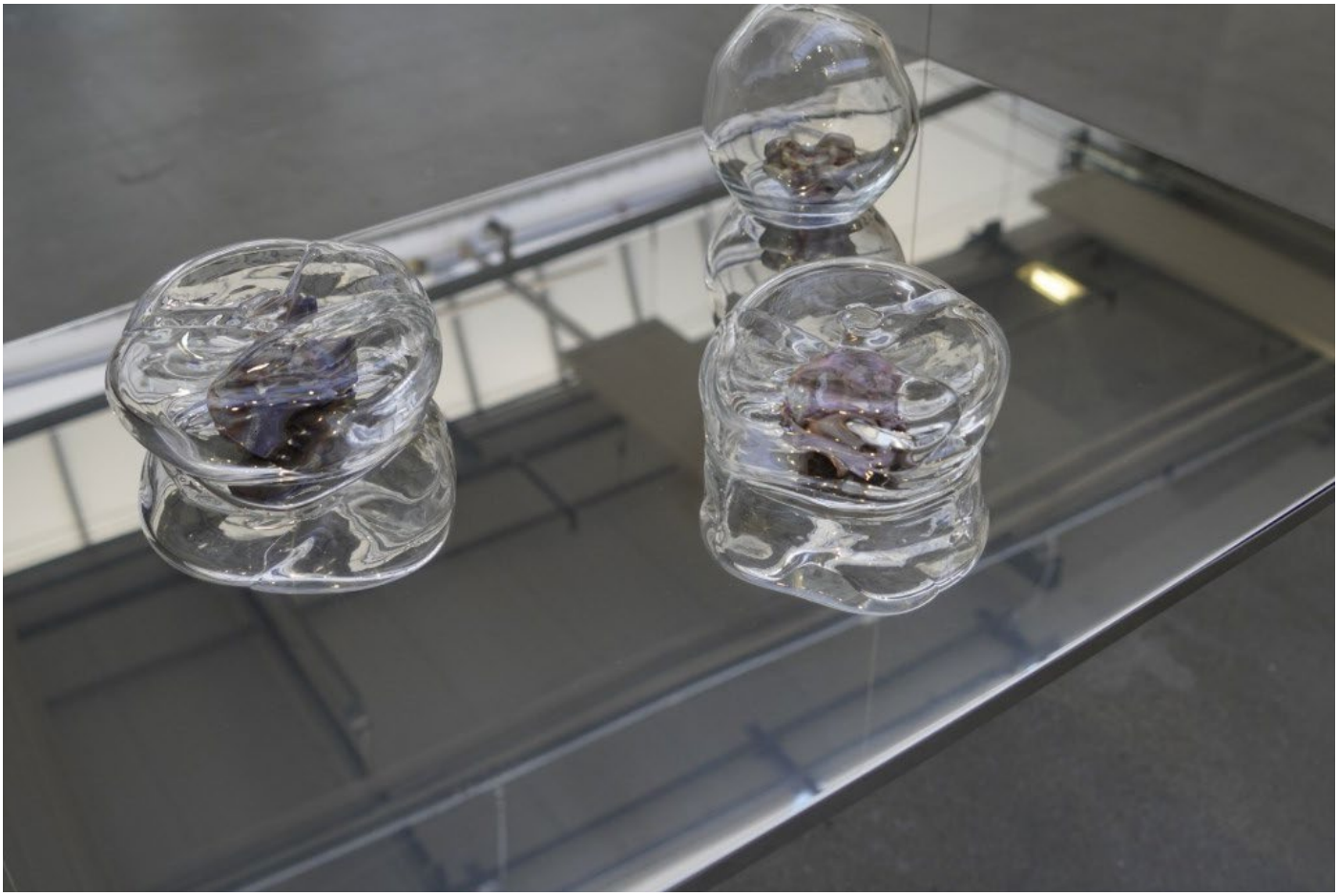


Image 53. Helene Kask & Luke Holden (glass objects), *Talismanic Bodies: Organisms,* 2026.



Image 54. Helene Kask, *Talismanic Bodies: Liquid Gold,* 2026.



Image 55. Helene Kask, *Talismanic Bodies: Liquid Gold,* 2026.